without any exceptions. The Chinese presumed that India would not dare to go against the collective decision of the N-5. Therefore, they struggled to comprehend the new situation created by the Indian nuclear tests. Their broad assessment was that India was attempting to squeeze into the ranks of the nuclear states without caring for the price in terms of worsening India–China relations.

A well-known Chinese strategic expert alleged that there was a strong domestic motivation behind these nuclear tests, that the tests helped the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) to consolidate its grip on power by talking up an external threat. [16] They surmised that the BJP wanted to exploit fault-lines between China and America in order to break apart the international coalition against India's nuclear tests. Despite the substantial improvement in Sino-US relations by the late 1990s (by which time they had repaired the damage caused to the relationship by the fallout from the Tiananmen incident of 1989), the Chinese were concerned about the prospects of being 'contained' by the United States. The presumption may have been that the nuclear tests would have strengthened India's position as a 'containing factor' for the Americans against China. [17] Hence, China's two primary questions immediately after the nuclear tests were: What would the Americans do next in terms of dealing with India's nuclear tests?; and, how could China protect her international image from the damage arising as a result of Indian accusations that China was a threat?

The Americans had also been caught by surprise by the Indian nuclear tests, which was all the greater because the Clinton administration had discovered and pre-empted an earlier effort during the administration of Prime Minister P.V. Narasimha Rao to test nuclear devices in December 1995. [18] The Chinese would have been relieved when President Clinton reacted strongly to news of the tests. Avowing that 'India has